

CAN FACEBOOK BE TRUSTED?

It seems that Facebook is lying through their teeth. The advertising model on an open internet can easily pay for the entire Free Basics program and allow Facebook to foot the TSP's bill, especially when Google says so. Which begs the question of placing our trust on Facebook.

Will they be fair? History says, no.

Consider the case of WhatsApp, the extremely popular messaging client that was bought by Facebook. Around November last year, news about Telegram

But these can always be interpreted vaguely, like the very first criteria is that of 'efficiency'. Facebook dictates that participants should not use JavaScript, VoIP, video, file transfer, or photos larger than 200 KB. These criteria are well defined but then they mention that secure content is not allowed. So no transactions whatsoever? They also mention that services will need to use a Dual Certificate HTTPS implementation. Those with furrowed brows should read up on Lenovo's SuperFish and Dell's incident with self-attested

Strike three! You're out!

Let's now take a look at all the countries where Free Basics is operational. Take Bogota for example. Karisma, a digital-rights group in Bogota came across a troubling discovery. Here's what Carolina Botero, Karisma's President had to say, "We have done some informal inquiries in the neighborhoods and found that people don't realize they are only on Facebook—not on the Internet". The phrase 'walled garden' suddenly comes to mind. Or if we are to phrase it in another manner. This is exactly what is meant by a two-tier internet. One is which Facebook and TSPs maintain a stranglehold over. And the other is the real open and expensive internet.

WELCOME TO THE MATRIX, GANESH!

We can never say if we'll ever come across a pop-culture reference so apt for this situation. Those poor people whose first experience of the Internet is what Facebook decides to show him is akin to the machines hooking newborn babies straight into the matrix – an artificial world created to enslave human beings to be a source of energy, simply put, a battery. Free Basics is nothing but the same, an ecosystem that considers its subjects to be sources of revenue. It will mine their data and later sell the same to the highest bidder.

Also, if you are to believe that Facebook's altruistic intentions are nothing but the beginning of an elaborate bait and switch, then you wouldn't be wrong. Because this wouldn't be the first time it would have resorted to such a tactic. Previously, Facebook spent an equally ridiculous amount of money convincing brands to invest in establishing Facebook pages and building a community around it. And once brands had invested a lot of money to build such a presence on Facebook, it modified its algorithms to reduce the 'reach' of community pages under the pretext of ramping up its privacy policies. The organic 'reach' was effectively reduced to an average of six per cent. So if you happen to be a big brand who spent a lot in getting a lot of people to 'Like' your page, then your posts – after the policy change – will only be shown to about six per cent of your fans unless ... you paid up.



Average Revenue Per User (ARPU)

– a competing messaging client – started doing the rounds. And being the popular mode of communication that WhatsApp is, a lot of people started spreading the word about Telegram via WhatsApp.

And they discovered something very peculiar.

WhatsApp had made it so, that whenever a link to Telegram's website was shared on WhatsApp, not only was the link not clickable but you couldn't even copy the text so that you could paste it in a web browser. Users had to manually type in the URL after getting a message on WhatsApp. It is understandable that WhatsApp wouldn't want a rival client getting publicised via its own platform but what this incident tells us is that, Facebook, through WhatsApp wishes to retain a level of control over what their users see.

Strike one!

The apps and services that will be allowed onto the Free Basics platform have to adhere to a strict set of guidelines designed to reduce their data footprint.

certificates. It essentially allows Facebook to access all data that it being transferred between its servers. If there is a strict vetting process to get onto the platform, why would Facebook want to access their user's data? Oh wait! That's how Facebook makes money.

Strike two!

Speaking of the vetting process, Facebook did receive quite a bit of flak when they mentioned that they'll be doing the vetting process themselves. So when they decided to name a 'third-party', whom did they pick? IMAI and NASSCOM. IMAI stands for the Internet and Mobile Association of India. If the name didn't make it obvious, then let it be clear that the so called 'third-party' is a lobby for the very Telcos that Facebook plans to tie up with. As if that wasn't proof of ulterior motives, then Krithiga Reddy, Facebook's MD is the Vice-Chairman. It seems Facebook not only defines Net Neutrality incorrectly, but they seem to consider the term 'third-party' to be equivalent to family.